

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 60 Summary

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This lesson addresses a common challenge for English speakers learning Spanish: how to correctly place prepositions in Spanish questions. In English, it is natural to end a question with a preposition (e.g., “What are you thinking about?”), but Spanish grammar prohibits this structure. Instead, prepositions must appear at the beginning of the question. Paul explains this pattern through examples and highlights its importance for creating grammatically correct sentences, especially when working with verbs that require specific prepositions.

Spanish Does Not End Sentences with Prepositions

Unlike English, where ending a sentence or question with a preposition is common, Spanish strictly places the preposition at the beginning of the clause or question. This is especially relevant when asking about things like:

- What are you going to dress up as? → ¿**De qué** te vas a disfrazar?
- What are you thinking about? → ¿**En qué** piensas?
- What is María complaining about? → ¿**De qué** se queja María?

The rule is simple: **if the verb requires a preposition, the question must begin with that preposition.**

Learn Verbs with Their Required Prepositions

Paul emphasizes learning verbs alongside their prepositions to avoid errors. Examples:

- *Disfrazarse de* – to dress up as
 - ¿De qué te vas a disfrazar?
- *Pensar en* – to think about
 - ¿En qué piensas?
- *Quejarse de* – to complain about
 - ¿De qué se queja María?

These prepositions are not optional in Spanish—even if they don't appear in the English equivalent.

Example: “Hablar de” – to talk about

- Statement: Quiero hablar de la fiesta.
- Question: ¿De qué quieres hablar?

This transformation demonstrates how the preposition *de* moves to the front of the question phrase.

Example: “Arrepentirse de” – to regret something

Although English omits the preposition (“Do you regret what you did?”), Spanish requires it:

- Statement: Me arrepiento de lo que hice.
- Question: ¿De qué te arrepientes?

Note the irregular conjugation *te arrepientes* from the reflexive verb *arrepentirse*. Even if learners are unfamiliar with the verb, understanding the pattern allows them to construct the question correctly.

The Power of Patterns

Paul advocates for learning Spanish through sentence patterns rather than isolated vocabulary. Once learners internalize structures like “¿[Preposition] + qué + [verb]?”, they can apply them flexibly to new verbs and situations, even if they’ve never seen the specific sentence before.

Conclusion

Mastering the placement of prepositions in Spanish questions is essential for sounding natural and avoiding common grammatical mistakes. The key is to learn the required prepositions along with the verb and to move those prepositions to the front when forming questions. This pattern-based approach allows learners to build new, grammatically correct sentences with confidence and speed.